

have, the watch costs almost half of what the Galaxy Gear costs. This would make it lucrative for many customers.

Further, if the better known ones do not fit your fancy then go ahead for the Burg Smartwatch and the Casio G-Shock Digital Bluetooth watch. Both feature voice recorders and MP3 and MP4 players. The Burg smartwatch also features a phonebook that can store up to 500 numbers.

Sony is also still selling its original Sony Smartwatch, which is more of a budget option. It has the features of a smartwatch but comes at less than half the price when compared to the Galaxy Gear.

The Casio G-Shock on the other hand applies only to the iPhone 4S and iPhone 5 owners. It has lesser features than the others and frankly pales in comparison in this department.

Price

When a tech firm comes up with a device, a huge amount of R&D goes into commercialising it. This in part means making the device cheap enough to sell to the general public. One of the main reasons why the market for smartwatches is still developing is their pricing. Take the Galaxy Gear for example, not everyone can spend ₹ 70,000 plus to buy the Galaxy Note 3+ Gear combo. On the other hand, the standalone price of the device is not small either.

The buzzword here is value.

Are you going to try and churn out every ounce of functionality from your device? If so, spending well on a smartwatch does make sense for you. If not, go for the cheaper models.

Functionality

Not every smartwatch provides the same kind of functionality. While Galaxy Gear and Sony Smartwatch 2 provide pretty much the same functions, the one big difference is that you can use any Android phone with the latter. As mentioned before, this is a huge plus, especially considering the fact that the cheaper Galaxy devices do not support the Gear yet.

Similarly, if you are choosing between the Burg and Casio models, then

Burg is the hands down winner functionally wise.

Looks

As with many other things in our mind, looks play a big role in choosing a smartwatch. This is a big reason behind the accolades received by the Pebble smartwatches. A smartwatch is still a watch and you would not want a grotesque device to be wrapped around your wrist.

Subjective as this decision is, the Pebble Steel, launched at CES 2014, is considered by most to be the best in the looks department. The Casio G-Shock looks like your traditional swanky G-shock watch. The Burg 13 smartwatches on the other hand present more colourful options, as does the Sony Smartwatch 2 SW2. The Galaxy Gear though has been criticised a bit looks wise.

Conclusion

In the post Mobile World Congress (MWC) 2014 era, the market for smartwatches has been changing. Samsung has ditched Android to launch its proprietary Tizen-powered Gear 2, Gear 2 Neo and Gear Fit smartwatches. Incidentally, the Gear Fit was awarded the best mobile device title at MWC 2014.

Samsung dropped the highly successful Galaxy branding for its smartwatches (using its proprietary Tizen platform) and Google followed with the Android Wear platform meant solely for wearables. The LG G Watch and Moto 360 smartwatches from LG and Motorola respectively have created some waves with their introductory videos. The companies have all promised an evolution in wearable computing, which is just what we have been saying all along. Smartwatches are here and they are evolving. In addition, the market is expanding with newer products entering the competition.

Yet, buying a smartwatch still depends on the need, 'to buy or not to buy,' indeed that is the question. Whether you want such a device enough and are going to use it is what decides whether you are going to buy it. ●

The author is a correspondent at EFTimes.com



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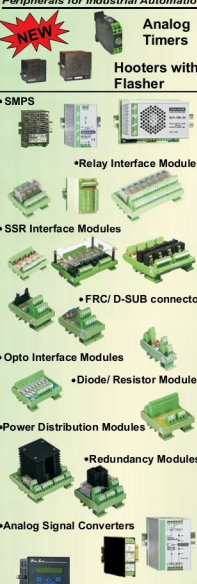
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